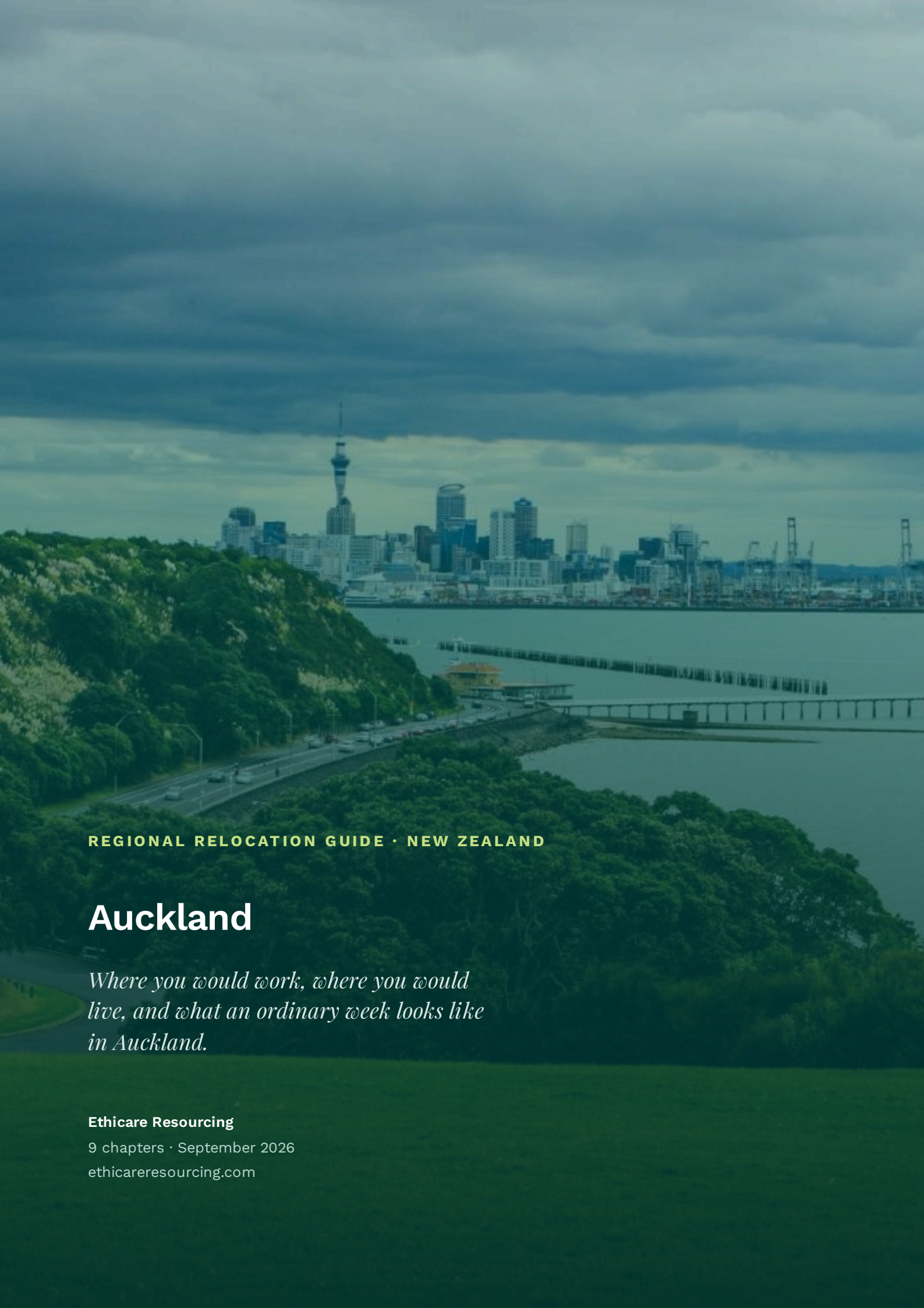


A wide-angle photograph of the Auckland skyline across a body of water. The Sky Tower is the most prominent feature in the center of the skyline. To the right, several large port cranes are visible. In the foreground, a multi-lane highway runs along a green, tree-covered hillside. A long pier extends from the shore into the water. The sky is filled with heavy, grey clouds.

REGIONAL RELOCATION GUIDE • NEW ZEALAND

# Auckland

*Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Auckland.*

**Ethicare Resourcing**

9 chapters • September 2026

[ethicareresourcing.com](http://ethicareresourcing.com)

## What's inside

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**01    Welcome to Auckland**

---

**02    Auckland at a glance**

---

**03    Where clinicians live**

---

**04    Cost of living**

---

**05    Getting around**

---

**06    Food, shopping & the everyday**

---

**07    Why Auckland, honestly**

---

**08    Healthcare in Auckland**

---

**09    Weekends & the outdoors**

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**This guide is free, and so is everything in it.** Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

# Welcome to Auckland

Auckland Guide · Chapter 1 of 9



Tāmaki Makaurau — Tāmaki desired by many. A city of a million and a half people built across fifty volcanoes, between two harbours, with a rainforest on one side and an ocean on the other. The city sits on an isthmus barely a kilometre wide at its narrowest point. You are never more than about half an hour from water.

## A welcome from Sophie

*Moving to the other side of the world is a big thing to do. I know, because I did it.*

*Twenty-odd years ago I arrived in Australia on a working holiday visa, having backpacked my way across Southeast Asia, and then made my way to New Zealand. I lived and worked in Wellington. I managed a backpackers in Queenstown, where I met my partner. I stayed for years, and Aotearoa has never really left me.*

*So when I talk to a radiographer in Manchester or a sonographer in Johannesburg who is trying to work out whether to do this, I am not reading from a brochure. I remember the particular feeling of standing in a supermarket in a new country and not recognising a single brand. I remember how long it took before it stopped feeling like a very long holiday.*

*What I did not have, then, was anything like this guide. Most relocation material is either a list of visa requirements or a tourism advertisement, and neither of those tells you what a Tuesday actually looks like. That is the gap this is trying to fill: what it costs, where people live, what the winters are really like in an Auckland house, what you will miss, and what you will gain.*

*We have written it honestly, including the parts that are less flattering. If Auckland is not right for you, we would far rather you worked that out here, at your kitchen table, than eighteen thousand kilometres from home.*

*And if it is right — and for a great many clinicians it turns out to be — then this should save you a year of learning things the slow way.*

**SOPHIE CAREEM — FOUNDER & CEO, ETHICARE RESOURCING**



A café by the water

## Auckland in nine numbers

The shape of the place, before anything else.

1.7 million

People — roughly a third of New Zealand's population, in one city

48

Volcanic cones across the city, most of them public parks

2 km

The narrowest point of the isthmus, harbour to harbour

200+

Ethnicities — one of the most diverse cities anywhere

4 in 10

Aucklanders born overseas. You will not be unusual

4

Major public hospitals, plus a fast-growing private sector

40 min

Coast to coast — sheltered gulf to Tasman surf

~NZ\$700

Median weekly rent, three-bedroom house

Rarely

How often it frosts. Mild, humid, and green all year

## How to use this guide

Nobody reads sixteen chapters in order. Where you start depends entirely on where you are in the decision – each chapter stands on its own and points to the two or three that follow naturally from it.

Still deciding

[History & culture](#) and [Why Auckland, honestly](#) – what living here actually feels like, and the honest trade-offs.

Job confirmed

[Where clinicians live](#) and [Getting around](#) – the chapters people spend longest in.

Date booked

[Your first month](#) – the four things that unlock everything else, in the order they have to happen.

Already here

[Finding your people](#) – the part that decides whether you stay.

## What this is, and isn't

What it is

Written by people who have made this move and who place clinicians into it every week.

Honest about cost, distance and the things that are harder here.

Specific to Auckland. National topics are explained once in the [master guide](#) and linked, never repeated.

What it isn't

Immigration or tax advice. We point to the official source every time it matters.

A tourism brochure. If Auckland doesn't suit you, we'd rather you found that out here.

Fixed. Figures are indicative and current as at July 2026 – costs, rules and timings change.

# Auckland at a glance

Auckland Guide · Chapter 3 of 9



The shape of the city, who arrived when, what fills the calendar, and how people get about — the orientation that makes your first week easier.

## A city on a narrow waist of land

Auckland sits on an isthmus barely two kilometres across at its narrowest — the Waitematā Harbour on one side, the Manukau on the other. Understanding that shape explains almost everything about commuting here. Select a place to see where it sits.

Waitematā Harbour Manukau Harbour Hauraki Gulf  
A schematic — not to scale, and not a map for navigating by.

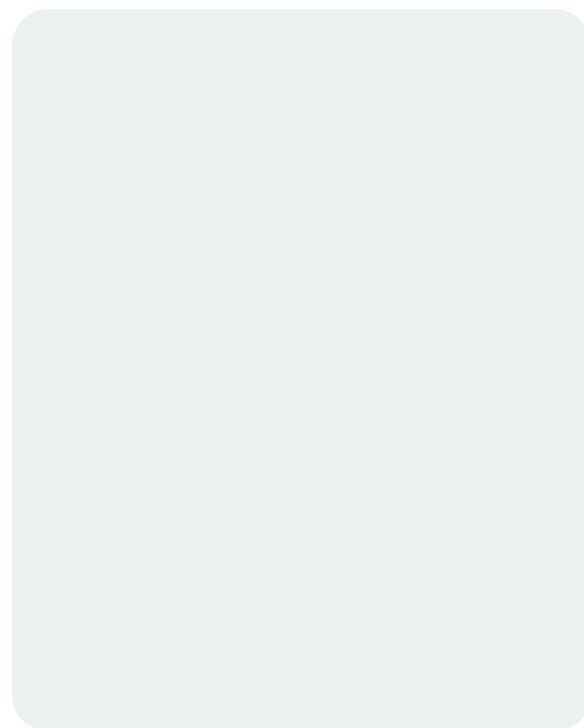
The Sky Tower, lit up over the central city

## Built on volcanoes

The volcanic field beneath Auckland has erupted around fifty times over the last 200,000 years, and each eruption left a cone, a crater or a lava flow. What that means today is a city interrupted, pleasantly, by hills — most of them public parks.

Māori built fortified *pā* on the largest of them. Maungawhau (Mount Eden), Maungakiekie (One Tree Hill) and Takarunga (Mount Victoria) still carry the terracing, and the views from the top are the quickest way to understand how the city fits together. Rangitoto, the youngest cone, rose from the sea only about 600 years ago and was watched from shore as it formed.

Practically speaking, it means most suburbs have a hill you can walk up before work, and that the flat run between them is where the motorways went.



Where Auckland sits, with the straight-line distance to Hamilton

## How the city became this mixed

You will not be the first person to arrive here from a long way away. That is the single most useful thing to know about Auckland.

From c. 1350 · Tāmaki Makaurau

Māori settlement across the isthmus — gardens, portage routes between the harbours, and *pā* on the volcanic cones. The name means the place desired by many.

1840s · A colonial capital

Founded as the capital of the new colony, and briefly the seat of government before it moved to Wellington. British and Irish settlers, and a port that never stopped growing.

1950s–70s · The Pacific arrives

Samoan, Tongan, Cook Island and Niuean families came for work, largely to South and West Auckland. Auckland is now the largest Polynesian city in the world.

1990s onward · Asia, and everywhere

Chinese, Indian, Korean, Filipino and South African communities reshaped whole suburbs — and, gratifyingly, the food. Dominion Road alone is worth the move.

Today · Two hundred ethnicities

Roughly four in ten Aucklanders were born overseas. In a hospital tearoom that means you are unremarkable, in the best possible way.

## **Four weekends worth putting in your diary**

Dates shift year to year, so check before you plan – but these four are the ones people talk about.

Jun / Jul · Matariki

The Māori new year, marked by the rising of the Pleiades and now a public holiday. Dawn ceremonies, light installations, and a genuine national pause.

March · Pasifika

The largest Pacific festival in the world, spread across villages in Western Springs Park – one for each nation, each with its own food and stage.

Oct / Nov · Diwali

Aotea Square fills with dance, food stalls and fireworks. One of several festivals the city puts on for communities it is genuinely proud of.

Feb / Mar · Lantern Festival

Lunar New Year, marked with hundreds of lit lanterns in the Domain and a night market that is worth arriving hungry for.

## **Four ways people move about**

Auckland Transport runs the buses, trains and ferries under one fare system. Get an AT HOP card in your first week – it's cheaper than paying cash and works on everything.

Ferries

Commuter and island services cross the Waitematā to Devonport, Half Moon Bay, Hobsonville and Waiheke. The Devonport run takes twelve minutes and is, objectively, a better commute than a car.

Trains & buses

Four rail lines plus frequent bus routes on the main arterials, now running through the City Rail Link beneath the centre.

Driving

Still how most households get about. One motorway spine, one harbour crossing, and a peak that is narrow but firm.

Walking & cycling

Better than its reputation, particularly along the waterfront and the Northwestern path. E-bikes have made the hills a non-issue.

The full detail – licences, buying a car, running costs and the traffic honestly – is in [Getting around](#).

## The year, in four parts

Auckland's climate is mild — no snow, no extremes, and you can swim from December to April. What catches people is the rhythm rather than the weather: when the country works, when it stops, when flights cost double, and why a fourteen-degree winter can feel colder than a British one.

## The year, in four parts

Averages for the city, so treat them as the shape rather than a forecast. Auckland's real signature is variability — four seasons in a day is a cliché because it's accurate.

|             |
|-------------|
| Summer      |
| Dec – Feb   |
| 20–24°      |
| Avg daytime |
| Autumn      |
| Mar – May   |
| 17–21°      |
| Avg daytime |
| Winter      |
| Jun – Aug   |
| 11–15°      |
| Avg daytime |
| Spring      |
| Sep – Nov   |
| 15–19°      |
| Avg daytime |

Sea temperature peaks in February rather than January — the water lags the air by about a month. Summer daylight runs until around nine, which is what makes an after-shift swim practical.

## For about a month, the country genuinely closes

From a few days before Christmas until well into January, New Zealand stops. Not slows — stops. Trades go away, offices run on skeleton staff, businesses close for two or three weeks with a note on the door, and the whole country appears to be at a beach somewhere.

This is lovely if you're on holiday and genuinely difficult if you've just arrived. It's the single most important thing in this chapter for anyone choosing a start date.

If you can choose your start date

**February or late March are the easiest months to land in.** Everything is open, the weather is still excellent, school has started so the rental market has settled, and you get four good months before winter.

October is the next best. Mid-December is the hardest — you'll arrive to closed offices, no trades available and a rental market that has gone quiet.

## Fourteen degrees outside can feel colder than four

This is the complaint you'll hear from every British, Irish and Northern European arrival, and it isn't imagined. Auckland winters are mild by any measure – daytime highs around fourteen, frost almost unheard of, no snow. But the older housing stock was built for a warm climate on the assumption that nobody would need central heating, and a great many houses are single-glazed, under-insulated and unheated in the rooms you're not sitting in.

Add humidity. Auckland is damp, and a damp fourteen degrees inside a still room is unpleasant in a way a dry four degrees with a radiator is not. The consequence people are least prepared for is mould – on window reveals, in wardrobes, behind furniture against an external wall.

The Healthy Homes standards have improved rentals substantially, and a modern or well-renovated house is entirely comfortable. But the habits are different from what you're used to, and they're learnable in a week.

The winter habits nobody tells you

Open windows for ten minutes every morning, even in winter. Moving air is what stops mould, not heat.

A dehumidifier is standard equipment here, not a luxury. Run it overnight in the wettest rooms.

Dry washing outside or in a vented dryer, never on a rack in a closed bedroom.

Heat the room you're in, and shut the door. Whole-house heating is rare and expensive.

Pull furniture a few centimetres off external walls so air can move behind it.

The five Healthy Homes standards a rental must meet, and what to look for at a viewing, are set out in the [Moving to New Zealand guide](#).

## The school year runs with the calendar year, not across it

Four terms, starting in late January or early February and finishing in mid-December, with two-week breaks between and six weeks over summer. If you're moving children mid-year, this is the detail that reshapes your timing.

Term 1 · Late Jan – mid Apr

The start of the school year. New classes, new teachers, and the easiest point to join.

Term 2 · Late Apr – early Jul

The long grey stretch. Fine to join, but socially harder than term one.

Term 3 · Mid Jul – late Sep

Winter sport, and the term most families find longest.

Term 4 · Mid Oct – mid Dec

Short, sunny and full of end-of-year events. A difficult term to arrive into.

## Timing the trip back is worth real money

Long-haul fares from New Zealand swing enormously with the season, and the expensive windows are predictable. Getting this right once a year is worth more than most of the savings in [Cost of living](#).

Cheapest windows

February to early April, and late October to mid-November. School is in, the shutdown is over, and fares drop noticeably.

Most expensive

Mid-December to mid-January, and the two-week school holidays. Book six to nine months ahead or pay double.

Plan for one long trip rather than several short ones

Twenty-four hours of flying each way makes a ten-day visit hard on everybody.

Most people here take three or four weeks and go once every year or two.

Build the annual-leave request in early — hospital rosters fill months ahead.

## **Bring layers and rain gear, not thickness**

The single most common packing mistake is a heavy winter coat that never comes out of the wardrobe, and no genuinely waterproof jacket.

Bring

Merino layers, a proper waterproof shell, sturdy walking shoes, prescription medicines with documentation, and anything in a hard-to-find size.

Leave behind

Heavy winter coats, thermal boots, snow gear, and most electrical appliances — the plug and voltage differ.

Buy on arrival

A dehumidifier, a good heater, sunscreen, jandals, and a set of togs. All cheap here, and none worth the baggage allowance.

*“The first Christmas is the strange one. Thirty degrees, a barbecue, everyone at the beach, and light until nine at night — and somewhere underneath it a small part of you expecting dark afternoons and the smell of a kitchen at home. Plan for it rather than being surprised by it. Ring people at their Christmas Eve, not yours. And then go swimming on Christmas morning, because by the second year that is the bit you would not give up.”*

SOPHIE CAREEM — FOUNDER & CEO, ETHICARE RESOURCING

# Where clinicians live

Auckland Guide · Chapter 5 of 9



Where you land shapes your commute and, if you have children, your school zone. Pick the hospital you'll work at and the list re-sorts around it — because the right suburb in Auckland is mostly a question of which way you drive in the morning.

Villa-lined streets in Devonport, on the North Shore

Where will you work?

Narrow it down

Sort by

A tip on choosing

Where you live can decide which state school your children attend. Zone boundaries can run down the middle of a street, so check the exact address is in-zone **before** you sign.

Most rentals are advertised on [Trade Me Property](https://www.trademe.co.nz/a/property) (<https://www.trademe.co.nz/a/property>) and [realestate.co.nz](https://www.realestate.co.nz) (<https://www.realestate.co.nz/>), and good ones move quickly.

Many clinicians rent short-term first and get to know a few areas before committing to a longer lease.

Rents are indicative weekly figures for a typical three-bedroom home, July 2026. Commute times are door-to-door driving estimates outside peak – add meaningfully at 8am, and more if you cross the harbour bridge.

How renting works here – applications, bond, tenancy rights and the Healthy Homes standards – is the same everywhere in New Zealand, and the [Moving to New Zealand guide](#) walks through it step by step.

## Three questions, in this order

One · Which hospital?

In Auckland this decides more than anywhere else in New Zealand. The city is long, the harbour splits it, and a suburb that is twenty minutes from one campus can be fifty from another in traffic. Pick the site first, then the suburb – not the other way round.

Two · Which side of the bridge?

The Auckland Harbour Bridge is the single biggest variable in a commute here. Living on the North Shore and working in the central city means crossing it twice a day, and at peak that is a genuinely different proposition from the off-peak estimate. If you are going to cross it daily, drive the route at 8am before you sign anything.

Three · School zone or square metres?

With school-age children the zone usually decides the suburb, and the most sought-after zones carry a substantial rent premium. Families without that constraint can go further out and get considerably more house. Be honest about which of the two you actually are.

## Reading the map

Auckland is really several cities that grew into each other, and they behave differently.

Central

The isthmus – Mount Eden, Epsom, Ponsonby, Grey Lynn, Remuera. Villas, volcanic cones, the best-regarded state school zones and the highest prices. Walkable, and close to the central hospital campus.

North Shore

Across the bridge – Devonport, Takapuna, Milford, Albany. Beaches on the doorstep, strong schools, a slightly separate identity. Excellent unless you cross the bridge at peak.

West

New Lynn out to Titirangi and the Waitākere Ranges. Bush, black-sand surf beaches, more space for the money, and a genuinely different feel from the isthmus.

South & east

Manukau, Howick, Botany and the eastern bays. The most diverse part of the city, the best value on family housing, and where a large share of the health workforce actually lives.

How renting works nationally – applications, bond, tenancy rights and the Healthy Homes standards – is the same everywhere, and set out in [Renting in New Zealand](#).

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# Cost of living

Auckland Guide · Chapter 7 of 9



Auckland is New Zealand's most expensive city, and housing is the reason. Everything else is closer to what you're used to than you might fear.

## Why there are no prices on this page

We used to print a weekly rent and a monthly budget table here. We have taken them out. A figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later, and a candidate who plans a move around a stale number is worse off than one who plans around none.

What does not go stale is the relationship between places — which suburb, ring or region you choose — and the judgement about which costs catch people out. That is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Auckland against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

Two things are worth saying before any numbers. First, prices here include GST — the figure on the shelf is the figure you pay, and restaurant bills carry no service charge or expectation of a tip. Second, salaries are quoted as gross annual figures and most healthcare staff are paid fortnightly.

Beyond that, the honest summary is simple. Housing will take a bigger share of your income than you're probably used to. Food is comparable. Fuel and cars are cheaper than the UK and dearer than the US. Eating out is reasonable, alcohol is not, and electronics cost more than they should because everything arrives by ship.

## Build your month

Four choices, and a monthly range you can take to a conversation about salary.

Who is moving

Where you'd rent

Add or remove

Monthly range—per month, before tax and savings

Indicative New Zealand dollars, July 2026. Excludes tax, KiwiSaver, student loan repayments and one-off setup costs.

## The trolley test

The quickest way to calibrate a new country is to price a week's shopping. These are supermarket and high-street prices, GST included.

Two local habits worth knowing

Fruit and vegetables are strongly seasonal and dramatically cheaper in season — buying what's abundant is how people here keep the grocery bill down.

Pak'nSave is genuinely much cheaper than New World for the same basket.

Bring your own bags: single-use plastic bags are banned.

### WHAT MOVES IN YOUR FAVOUR, AND WHAT DOESN'T

Compared with the UK, Ireland and most of Europe. Coming from the Gulf or the United States the picture shifts, particularly on tax and on cars.

#### Cheaper here

##### Cars

The used Japanese import market makes a reliable second car genuinely affordable.

##### Being outdoors

Regional parks, beaches, walking tracks and DOC campsites cost little or nothing. The default weekend is free.

##### Club sport and children's activities

A season of junior football or netball costs a fraction of what most arrivals expect.

##### Seasonal produce, meat and dairy

Bought in season, from the right supermarket, food is very reasonable.

##### Childcare for three to five year olds

The 20 Hours ECE subsidy takes a real bite out of the bill.

#### Dearer here

##### Rent, and by a distance

This is the line that reshapes your budget. Plan it first and everything else follows.

##### Alcohol

Excise duty is high. Local wine and beer are excellent and still not cheap.

##### Anything imported

Electronics, appliances, books, cosmetics, cycling kit. Everything arrives by ship, and the price shows it.

##### Heating an older house

Insulation standards have improved, but plenty of housing stock predates them.

Saturday market — in season is the whole trick

## **Work out your own numbers**

Costs vary by suburb and by household. These tools will get you closer than any average.

[Compare cities](#)



Auckland prices for rent, groceries, transport and dining, against your current city.

(<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Auckland>)

Plan your budget



New Zealand's free, government-backed budgeting tool.

(<https://sorted.org.nz/tools/budget-planner/>)

Official data



The Household Living-Costs Price Index, updated each quarter.

(<https://www.stats.govt.nz/topics/household-living-costs-price-indexes/>)

Property



Current rentals and homes for sale, for a real feel for the market.

(<https://www.realestate.co.nz/>)

Sanity check



A cleaner side-by-side of two cities. Worth running when Numbeo looks off.

(<https://www.expatistan.com/cost-of-living>)

Official rents



Bond-lodgement data by area – the most reliable rent figure in New Zealand.

(<https://www.tenancy.govt.nz/rent-bond-and-bills/market-rent/>)

Indicative New Zealand dollars, July 2026. Excludes tax, KiwiSaver, student loan repayments and one-off setup costs.

How pay is structured, what tax and KiwiSaver take, and what to check before accepting an offer are national – see our [salary guide](#) and the [master guide](#).

# Getting around

Auckland Guide · Chapter 6 of 9

Auckland has changed more in the last five years than in the previous fifty. It's still a car city — but some commutes are now genuinely faster without one.

It's still a car city

Most households run at least one car, and outside the central suburbs you'll want one. Plan on buying in your first month.

But transit is improving

The City Rail Link, the Northern Busway and the ferry network mean some commutes are now faster without a car than with one.

And the bridge decides a lot

One harbour crossing carries the whole North Shore. Whether you cross it daily is the single biggest variable in your week.

## You can drive on your own licence at first

Which takes the pressure off week one. But there's a clock running, and the conversion is easier if you start it early rather than in month eleven.

Day 1 · Drive on your overseas licence

Valid for up to twelve months from the date you arrive. Carry the licence itself, plus an official English translation or an international permit if it isn't in English.

Month 1-2 · Start the conversion

Apply at an AA or VTNZ agent. You'll need identity documents, your overseas licence, an eyesight check and the fee.

Before 12 months · Hold a NZ licence

Depending on which country issued yours, you may convert directly or may need theory and practical tests. Check which category applies before you book anything.

Four habits to pick up quickly

Drive on the left. Give way rules changed in 2012 and are now closer to what most people expect, but read them once properly.

Open-road speed is generally 100 km/h, and 50 km/h in urban areas unless signed otherwise.

Rural roads are narrow, unlit and often unsealed. Journey times are longer than the distance suggests – this catches out almost every newcomer on their first road trip.

One-lane bridges are real, and the sign tells you who gives way. The smaller arrow yields.

**Buying a car: cheaper than you expect, thanks to Japan**

New Zealand imports a large volume of used Japanese vehicles, which keeps second-hand prices well below what most people arriving from Europe or Africa are braced for. A tidy, reliable runabout costs less here than almost anywhere comparable.

**Where people buy.** Trade Me Motors is the default marketplace for private sales. Licensed dealers cost more but give you consumer protection and often a warranty. Car auctions are the cheapest route and the riskiest. If you're buying in your first fortnight, a dealer is the lower-stress option – you can always sell it on in a year.

Before you pay – four checks, in this order

A current Warrant of Fitness (WoF) and registration.

A pre-purchase inspection – the AA and others will do this for a modest fee, and it pays for itself.

A money-owing and stolen-vehicle check, so you don't inherit someone else's finance.

Odometer history – imports occasionally arrive with an optimistic reading.

| What your budget buys       | Indicative NZ\$ |
|-----------------------------|-----------------|
| Older import hatchback      | \$4k – \$8k     |
| Tidy family car, 8–12 years | \$9k – \$16k    |
| Newer SUV or hybrid         | \$20k – \$35k   |
| Pre-purchase inspection     | Around \$150    |

Indicative, July 2026. Prices move – treat these as orientation, not quotes.

Arriving without a car

Renting for the first two to four weeks is normal and sensible. It buys you time to open a bank account, get your address confirmed and view cars without hurrying.

Long-term rental deals are considerably cheaper than daily rates, and some employers can help with short-term arrangements – worth asking.

If you'll live centrally and work at Auckland City, it's genuinely worth trying a month without one before you commit.

**What it costs to run**

Petrol, insurance, the annual registration and a Warrant of Fitness. None of them is large on its own. The one that catches people out is **Road User Charges**: diesel and electric vehicles don't pay fuel tax at the pump, so they pay per thousand kilometres instead, bought in advance as a distance licence. If you buy a

diesel, budget for it.

Insurance here isn't compulsory, which surprises people arriving from the UK. Third-party cover is cheap and comprehensive cover isn't expensive by international standards. Get it anyway – and note that ACC covers injury from a crash regardless of fault or cover.

| Indicative running costs        | NZ\$                 |
|---------------------------------|----------------------|
| Petrol, 91 octane               | ≈ \$2.80 / litre     |
| Warrant of Fitness              | \$60 – \$90          |
| Annual registration             | Varies by vehicle    |
| Road User Charges – diesel & EV | Per 1,000 km         |
| Comprehensive insurance         | \$60 – \$150 / month |
| AA membership                   | Worth having         |

Registration and Road User Charge rates are set nationally and change – check Waka Kotahi for current figures.

## Trains, buses, ferries: one card, one network

Auckland Transport runs the buses, trains and ferries under a single zone-based fare system. Get an **AT HOP card** in your first week – it's materially cheaper than paying cash, and transfers between modes inside a journey are included.

### Trains

Four lines – Southern, Eastern, Western and Onehunga – now running through the City Rail Link beneath the centre, which adds new central stations and cuts journey times across the network. If your suburb has a station, use it.

### Buses & the busway

The Northern Busway has its own dedicated road and is often faster than driving from the Shore at peak. Elsewhere, frequent routes run every ten to fifteen minutes on the main arterials.

### Ferries

Devonport, Half Moon Bay, Hobsonville, Birkenhead and Waiheke, all from the downtown terminal. Devonport takes twelve minutes. The best commute in the city, and the one people move suburb for.

### Cycling

Better than its reputation. The Northwestern and waterfront paths are good, and e-bikes have made the hills a non-issue. Bikes travel free on ferries and, outside peak, on trains.

Fares are zone-based and reviewed regularly – check [at.govt.nz](https://at.govt.nz) for current prices. Under-fives travel free.

## Traffic, honestly

It isn't London or Jakarta. But it's a city of 1.7 million funnelled through one motorway spine and one harbour crossing, and pretending otherwise does nobody any favours.

Peak is narrow but firm

Roughly 7 to 9 in the morning and 4 to 6.30 in the evening. Shift work often means you miss both entirely, which is a genuine perk.

The bridge is the bottleneck

Everything from the North Shore crosses one structure. A twenty-minute run becomes fifty when it goes wrong, and it goes wrong without warning.

School terms change everything

The school holidays empty the roads noticeably. If you test a commute during a holiday you'll get a misleadingly good answer.

Rain adds fifteen minutes

Reliably, across the whole network. It's the local joke, and it's also true.

Friday afternoon starts early

From about two o'clock, particularly heading north or east out of the city. Long weekends are worse — leave Thursday night or Saturday morning.

Parking at hospitals is finite

Staff parking is usually available but rarely abundant, and often paid. Ask about it at interview — it's a legitimate question and affects your daily routine.

*“Don't buy a car in your first week. Rent something small, get your bank account and address sorted, and use the fortnight to work out whether you actually need one where you have landed. A surprising number of people discover they only need a car at weekends — and that changes the budget entirely.”*

SOPHIE CAREEM — FOUNDER & CEO, ETHICARE RESOURCING

Converting your licence, the paperwork and the rules of the road are national — the [Moving to New Zealand guide](#) covers them in full.

## A warm, mild climate

Auckland has the warmest climate of New Zealand's main centres: mild, humid summers and gentle winters, rarely cold, with the sea always close by.

What to pack

Layers and a light rain jacket year-round. Auckland weather can turn quickly.  
Homes are often cooler indoors than newcomers expect, so pack a warm layer even for summer evenings.

|             |
|-------------|
| Summer      |
| Dec – Feb   |
| 20–24°      |
| Avg daytime |
| Autumn      |
| Mar – May   |
| 17–21°      |
| Avg daytime |
| Winter      |
| Jun – Aug   |
| 11–15°      |
| Avg daytime |
| Spring      |
| Sep – Nov   |
| 15–19°      |
| Avg daytime |

# Food, shopping & the everyday

Auckland Guide · Chapter 8 of 9



Auckland takes coffee more seriously than almost anywhere and dinner less seriously than most. Whatever you cook at home, the city almost certainly sells it – the trick is knowing which street to drive to.

This is a city that eats early, brunches properly, and has excellent Asian and Pacific food at prices that make the restaurant scene look expensive by comparison. There are vineyards forty minutes from the hospital. There is also a coffee vocabulary you'll need on your first morning.

## The coffee is very good, almost everywhere

This is the part of daily life that most surprises people arriving from the UK. There's no chain-coffee default here. Independent cafés dominate, most of them buying from local roasters, and the standard at an ordinary suburban café is higher than at a specialist one in a lot of European cities. Espresso is the baseline, not the upgrade.

The flat white is claimed by both New Zealand and Australia, and the argument won't be settled in your lifetime. What matters practically is that it's the default order – espresso with steamed milk, less foam than a latte, in a smaller cup – and that ordering one correctly is a small, disproportionately satisfying milestone in your first week.

The other thing to know: cafés close early. Most stop serving mid-afternoon and many are shut by three. Brunch, not dinner, is the meal café culture is built around, and a weekend brunch here can comfortably take two hours.

Flat white

Espresso with steamed milk, less foam than a latte, smaller cup. The default.

Long black

Closest to an Americano – espresso poured over hot water.

Short black

An espresso. Ask for a double if you want a double.

Trim

Skim milk. "Trim flat white" is a complete order.

Fluffy

Warm frothed milk with chocolate dust, for small children. Usually free.

Long black, no water

What you order when what you actually want is a ristretto.

## **The clock runs earlier than you're used to**

A Saturday, roughly, in a city that gets up early and eats before it gets dark. The shift in timing is one of the genuine adjustments — and mostly a pleasant one.

7am

Cafés open and are already busy. Runners, dog walkers and the first flat whites of the day.

9–11am

Brunch proper, and the main social meal of the weekend. Expect a wait and don't rush it.

3pm

Most cafés stop serving. If you wanted lunch at three, you wanted it at two.

6–7pm

Dinner. Restaurants fill early and empty early — a 9pm booking is a late one.

Late

Limited. Auckland is not a late-night city, and that's a genuine adjustment rather than something you'll get used to.

## **Eight places, and what each is actually good at**

Auckland's best eating isn't concentrated in the centre. Several of the most interesting streets are ordinary suburban ones, and the food is better for it.

Dominion Road

The city's great Chinese street — hand-pulled noodles, hotpot and dumplings, for a fraction of restaurant prices.

Sandringham

South Asian, and excellent. Sweet shops, dosa, and the best-value dinner in Auckland.

Ponsonby Road

The polished strip — wine bars, small plates and the restaurants people book for birthdays.

Karangahape Road

Scrappier and more interesting. Where the newer, riskier kitchens open.

Britomart & Commercial Bay

Harbour-edge dining in the centre, handy after work and priced accordingly.

Otahuhu & Mangere

Pacific food at its best — umu, taro, and Saturday markets worth setting an alarm for.

Northcote & Takapuna

Korean and Japanese on the Shore, plus the beachfront cafés.

Titirangi & the west

Village cafés on the way to the ranges, and the reason a bush walk takes all morning.

The Auckland Night Markets rotate between shopping-centre car parks through the week – cheap, busy, and the best value street food in the city.

## Wine within an hour

Auckland isn't New Zealand's most famous wine region and doesn't need to be. What it has is proximity – four distinct areas close enough for an ordinary Sunday.

Waiheke Island

Forty minutes by ferry, which improves it considerably. Syrah, Bordeaux blends, and restaurants with a view over the gulf.

Kumeū & the north-west

Thirty minutes by car. Chardonnay, old family vineyards, and Sunday lunch among the vines.

Matakana

An hour north. A farmers' market, a cinema, oysters and a cluster of small producers.

Clevedon

Forty minutes south-east. Quiet, rural, and the one locals keep to themselves.

## Eating out is expensive. Eating well is not.

Restaurant prices will make you wince if you're arriving from anywhere with cheap labour or subsidised agriculture. The compensation is that the cheap end of Auckland eating is excellent rather than merely cheap.

| What it costs                    | Indicative NZ\$ |
|----------------------------------|-----------------|
| Flat white                       | \$5.50 – \$6.50 |
| Bakery lunch                     | \$10 – \$16     |
| Dominion Road noodles            | \$14 – \$20     |
| Weekend brunch                   | \$22 – \$32     |
| Mid-range dinner, per person     | \$25 – \$40     |
| Bottle of local wine, restaurant | \$45 – \$70     |

Two things that surprise people

**No tipping, no service charge.** Staff are paid a proper wage and tipping isn't expected anywhere. The menu price is the bill. Card payments sometimes carry a small surcharge, which will be signposted.

**BYO is a real thing.** Many smaller restaurants let you bring your own wine for a modest corkage fee, which changes the economics of eating out considerably.

A third of Aucklanders were born overseas, and the shops followed. This chapter is a practical directory: where the specialist grocers are, which supermarket to use for what, how to clothe a family for a New Zealand winter, and how to furnish an empty house in a fortnight without spending a fortune.

## Three things worth knowing before your first shop

01 · Two groups own the supermarkets

Foodstuffs runs PAK'nSAVE, New World and Four Square. Woolworths runs the rest.

Competition is thin, which is a large part of why groceries cost what they do – and why the specialist shops matter so much.

02 · The price on the shelf is the price

GST of 15% is already included in every ticket, everywhere, and there's no tipping culture to budget around. What you see is what leaves your account.

03 · Produce follows the season, properly

Imported fruit out of season is expensive and often poor. In season it's superb and cheap.

Cooking to what's in the shop is the single biggest saving available to a new household.

## Which shop for which job

Most households here end up splitting the week: a bulk shop at one chain, fresh produce somewhere cheaper, and a market at the weekend.

PAK'nSAVE

The cheapest of the big chains and the ugliest, cheerfully so. Warehouse shelving, bring your own bags, pack your own trolley. Where most families do the fortnightly bulk shop.

Woolworths

Formerly Countdown, renamed in 2024 – you'll still hear both names. The most familiar layout if you're arriving from the UK or Australia, and the strongest online delivery.

New World

Same owner as PAK'nSAVE, aimed higher. Better fresh counters, better bread, noticeably dearer. Useful for the things the bulk shop does badly.

Asian & specialist supermarkets

Frequently the cheapest fresh produce in the city, by a wide margin. Plenty of Auckland households buy vegetables, fish and rice here and everything else at a chain.

Four Square & dairies

The corner shop. A dairy is a small local convenience store – the word has nothing to do with milk, and it's the first bit of New Zealand English you'll need.

## Where to buy the food you grew up with

Areas rather than addresses, deliberately – individual shops open and close, but these neighbourhoods have held their character for decades and will still be there when you arrive.

South Asian

Sandringham, Papatoetoe and Mount Roskill. Spices, pulses, fresh curry leaves, halal butchers and sweet shops. Prices well below the chains for anything you'd buy in quantity.

East Asian

Dominion Road, Northcote and Botany. Full-size supermarkets rather than corner shops, with fish counters, fresh noodles and produce most chains don't stock.

Pacific

Ōtara, Māngere and Ōtāhuhu. Taro, green bananas, corned beef and the Saturday markets that anchor the whole community.

Middle Eastern

Mount Roskill and Sandringham again. Halal meat, bread, olives, cheeses and pantry staples, usually with a bakery attached.

African

Smaller and more scattered, largely in the south and west. Ask – the community networks know exactly where, and word of mouth beats a search engine.

British & Irish

Most of what you'd miss is in the chains' international aisle. The genuinely hard ones are proper sausages, decent bacon and specific chocolate.

## **Markets worth the drive**

Weekend markets are how a lot of people here shop, and how a lot of Saturday mornings get spent.

Ōtara Market · Saturday morning

The largest Pacific market in the country. Produce, seafood, and food stalls that are worth arriving hungry for. Finishes by midday.

La Cigale · Parnell, weekends

French-market baking, cheese, charcuterie and flowers. Expensive, excellent, and the pastry queue is real.

Avondale Sunday Market

South and East Asian produce in bulk at prices the chains can't approach. Bring cash and a big bag.

Matakana · Saturday

An hour north, and a whole morning out. Local producers, oysters, wine and a cinema next door.

Auckland Night Markets

Rotating between shopping-centre car parks through the week. Cheap, busy, and the best value street food in the city.

## **You need fewer warm clothes and much better rain gear**

Auckland winters are mild and wet rather than cold. Thick coats mostly stay in the wardrobe; a genuinely waterproof shell and merino layers get worn constantly. Houses are cooler indoors than you're used to, so what you wear at home matters more than what you wear outside.

Where people go

Sylvia Park is the largest centre in the country. Westfield Newmarket sits closest to the city hospitals, Commercial Bay is the smart end downtown, and Botany, Albany and LynnMall serve the east, north and west. All are on the rail or busway network.

Brands worth learning

Icebreaker for merino – the most useful thing you'll buy in your first month. Kathmandu and Macpac for outdoor and rain. Glassons and Hallenstein for everyday. Karen Walker and Kowtow at the design end.

Second-hand is unembarrassing

Hospice shops, Salvation Army stores and Save Mart are good and widely used across every income bracket. For children who grow out of things in a season, this is where sensible families shop.

Be honest with yourself

Range is narrower than a large European city and sales cycles are shorter. Shoes, children's clothes and anything imported in small volumes cost more. If you have a size that's hard to find, bring a year of it with you.

## **Unfurnished here can mean genuinely empty**

No fridge, no washing machine, sometimes no curtains. It catches almost every arrival out, and it's the reason the first fortnight costs more than the budget said.

Cheapest · Kmart, The Warehouse, Big Save

Kmart is where most new arrivals furnish the kitchen and the children's rooms in one afternoon. Briscoes covers homeware and is permanently mid-sale, which locals find funny and newcomers find confusing.

Middle · IKEA, Freedom, Nick Scali

IKEA opened at Sylvia Park in December 2025 – the first in the country, and a genuine change to how an empty house gets filled here. Danske Møbler sits at the better end.

Smartest · Trade Me and Marketplace

New Zealanders move house often, so the second-hand market is deep and unsnobbish. A good fridge or washing machine costs a fraction of new.

One thing nobody budgets for

Almost nothing is delivered free. Plenty of households own a tow bar and a trailer, and trailer hire is cheap and everywhere.

Factor a couple of hundred dollars of moving-things-around into your first month, or make friends with a neighbour who has a ute.

What a full household month actually costs, including the setup, is in **Cost of living**.

# Why Auckland, honestly

Auckland Guide · Chapter 2 of 9



Built on forty-eight dormant volcanoes between two harbours, Tāmaki Makaurau was prized long before it was a city. Here's what living in it actually feels like — and, just as usefully, when it's the wrong answer.

## Three reasons people choose it, and one they don't expect

01 · The deepest job market

A third of the country lives here, which means four major hospitals, every subspecialty, and room to move sideways without moving city.

02 · A genuinely international city

More than two hundred ethnicities, which in practice means your food, your festivals and your community already exist here.

03 · An hour to everywhere

Islands, surf and native bush inside an hour. Not a holiday — a Tuesday evening.

04 · The one nobody mentions

How quickly the pace of your week changes. It tends to land around week three, usually on an ordinary Wednesday.

## The forty-minute city

Auckland's real advantage isn't the city centre — it's how little of your life is spent getting anywhere. Choose a distance to see what the journey actually looks like.

From the harbour to the islands, a world of lifestyle sits within forty minutes of the city centre.

## A typical week, roughly

Rosters differ and no two departments are the same. But a normal week here has a shape, and it's roughly this.

Mon · Handover at 07:30

Departments here are smaller. You'll know everyone's name by Friday, including the porters'.

Tue · A late finish

Home by half six. In summer it's still light at nine, so the evening isn't over.

Wed · Netball, football, or the pool

Club sport costs very little and is how most newcomers meet people who aren't colleagues.

Thu · The weekly shop, and a plan

Pak'nSave for the week. Someone in the tearoom will have an opinion about where you should go on Saturday.

Fri · Dinner out, and a walk home

Ponsonby Road or the Viaduct. A mid-range meal runs about NZ\$25–\$40, and the walk back is along the water.

Sat · The market, then the coast

Forty minutes west to Piha. Black sand, real surf, and thinning crowds by four.

Sun · Nothing much

The Domain, a bakery, and being home in time for a Monday you don't dread.

## The honest version

We'd rather you knew both sides before you booked a flight. Nothing here should be a surprise once you arrive.

What it does brilliantly

Four major hospitals and every subspecialty — the widest choice of work in the country, without changing city.

Food, faith and community from almost anywhere. Halal butchers, Asian supermarkets, Pacific markets, and the largest Pacific festival in the world.

Islands, surf beaches and native rainforest all inside an hour of the CBD.

New Zealand's main international airport, which matters more than you think when family are far away.

What takes adjusting to

Housing is the most expensive in New Zealand — a three-bedroom house sits around NZ\$700 a week, and more in the central and beachside suburbs. Wages are higher here too, but plan for rent first.

The city is spread out. Public transport is improving and the City Rail Link helps, but most households still keep a car.

February is humid. Not unbearable, but a different kind of warm from a European summer.

It is genuinely far from Europe. Most people settle into one long trip home a year rather than several short ones.

## A mild year, and what you do in it

Warm, humid and coastal. Summers rarely get uncomfortable, winters stay mild, and frosts are rare. Rain arrives across the whole year rather than in one wet season.

Summer

Dec – Feb

20–24°

Avg daytime

Autumn  
Mar – May  
17–21°  
Avg daytime

Winter  
Jun – Aug  
11–15°  
Avg daytime

Spring  
Sep – Nov  
15–19°  
Avg daytime

*“I thought Auckland was going to feel really busy because it’s New Zealand’s biggest city. But coming from London, it feels so much slower and more relaxed. Being able to finish work and head to the beach is something I could only have dreamed of before we moved.”*

FESTUS, RADIOGRAPHER — MOVED FROM LONDON TO AUCKLAND

## The six things people ask

### Pace of life

Slower outside work, not inside it. The hospital is a hospital — busy, pressured, occasionally chaotic. What changes is the evening: shops shut earlier, people leave on time more often, and there’s a general social agreement that a weekend is for something other than work. The main adjustment is that Auckland isn’t a late-night city. If you love a midnight restaurant, that’s a genuine loss.

### Diversity

More than two hundred ethnicities, roughly four in ten Aucklanders born overseas, and the largest Polynesian population of any city in the world. Whole suburbs are shaped by their communities — South Asian around Sandringham and Papatoetoe, East Asian along Dominion Road and in Northcote, Pacific across the south. Practically: your food, your festivals and your place of worship almost certainly already exist here.

### Safety

New Zealand consistently ranks among the safest countries in the world, and for most people arriving from a large city the change is noticeable — children walking to school, unlocked back doors in some suburbs, an unarmed police service as the norm. It isn’t crime-free. Retail and vehicle crime get discussed a lot locally. But personal safety is rarely what worries people once they arrive.

#### Family friendliness

Auckland's strongest card. Free regional parks and beaches, cheap club sport, playgrounds everywhere, under-fives travelling free on public transport, and schools that expect children to be outside. The catch is grandparents. Being twenty-four hours from family is the hardest part of this move for most parents, and no amount of beach compensates for it entirely.

#### Commuting

Better than London or Sydney, worse than a mid-sized city. A car city with improving public transport — the City Rail Link and the Northern Busway have changed what's possible, and the ferries are pleasant. Twenty to thirty minutes door to door is realistic if you choose your suburb around your hospital. Fifty is what happens if you don't.

#### Outdoor lifestyle

The strongest single argument for the city. Fifty islands in the gulf, black-sand surf beaches forty minutes west, rainforest ranges on the doorstep, and a harbour built for sailing. All of it a Tuesday evening rather than an annual holiday. If you don't particularly like being outdoors, be honest with yourself: you're paying Auckland prices for something you won't use.

### **Four good reasons to choose somewhere else**

We'd rather place you somewhere you'll stay than somewhere that looked impressive on paper. If any of these sound like you, say so and we'll point you elsewhere in the country.

#### Rent is your main worry

Auckland housing is the most expensive in the country. Christchurch, Waikato and the Bay of Plenty will give you materially more house for the same salary.

#### You want to walk everywhere

Wellington is compact, walkable and hilly, with the whole city inside twenty minutes. Auckland is not that, and won't become it.

#### You want mountains and snow

Auckland is subtropical and flat by comparison. Christchurch, Central Otago and Queenstown are where the Alps are.

#### You want small and quiet

A third of the country lives here. If the appeal of New Zealand is that it's not a big city, don't move to the big city.

Every region has its own pace, cost of living and kind of work. It's worth reading a few before you narrow down — our [New Zealand destination guides](#) cover each one just as honestly.

## Coming from a big city?

What tends to change

**You gain** time. The commute shortens, the evening lengthens, and the weekend genuinely belongs to you.

**You gain** access — the coast, the bush and the islands are ordinary rather than an event.

**You miss** the density: the late restaurant, the last-minute concert, the airport that's four hours from anywhere in Europe.

**You miss** family, and it doesn't fade. Most people settle into one long trip home a year rather than several short ones.

These are impressions rather than measurements, and no ranking of cities is intended.

## Questions we're asked

The ones that come up most often when clinicians are weighing Auckland against everywhere else.

**Is Auckland too expensive to be worth it?**

**Do I need a car?**

**How long is a typical commute?**

**Which suburb should I look at first if I have children?**

**Is it easy to meet people?**

**What surprises people most?**

Where we'd steer you instead

If the housing market is the dealbreaker, [Waikato](#) and [Christchurch](#) both carry real clinical breadth at a materially lower entry price — and neither is a compromise on the work.

If you want a city you can live fifteen minutes from work in, [Wellington](#) is the honest answer. A smaller system, a shorter day.

If the traffic is what you would come to resent, the [Bay of Plenty](#) is growing quickly and the commute is a fraction of Auckland's.

In our experience

Auckland is the one place in New Zealand where the clinical scale genuinely rivals what you left. The clinicians who settle here are the ones who decided the breadth of the work was worth the price of the housing — and who chose their suburb around the commute rather than the listing.

# Healthcare in Auckland

Auckland Guide · Chapter 4 of 9



You'll work inside this system and, sooner or later, use it. Here's how it fits together — for you, and for your family.

Public healthcare is funded through general taxation and delivered by Health New Zealand | Te Whatu Ora as a single national organisation. Auckland's services sit across three metropolitan districts.

Alongside it sit two things newcomers rarely expect: a no-fault accident scheme that covers everybody, and a private sector growing faster than anyone here can remember.

## The public system

Free or heavily subsidised hospital care for residents and most work-visa holders. Emergency departments, planned surgery, maternity, mental health and specialist services all sit here.

## ACC

The Accident Compensation Corporation covers **everyone** in New Zealand — residents and visitors — for injury from accidents, no fault attached. Treatment, rehabilitation and some loss of earnings.

## Private cover

A large and fast-growing private sector handling mostly elective surgery, endoscopy and diagnostics. Many people hold insurance alongside the public system, and some employers contribute.

## The four public hospitals

Four major public hospitals serve the region, each with a distinct character and catchment. Which one you join shapes your commute, your caseload and your colleagues.

### Auckland City Hospital

One of New Zealand's largest tertiary hospitals — acute, surgical, specialist and emergency care, with Starship Children's Hospital on the same campus. Central, so most inner suburbs are a short commute.

#### Middlemore Hospital

A major South Auckland hospital, known nationally for its trauma, burns and plastic-surgery services. Serves one of the most diverse catchments in the country.

#### North Shore Hospital

Acute, medical and surgical services for the rapidly growing North Shore. Most staff live on the Shore rather than crossing the bridge twice a day.

#### Waitākere Hospital

Medical, maternity and outpatient services for West Auckland, with the Waitākere Ranges and the west-coast beaches on the doorstep.

### **A second system, growing quickly**

Auckland's private hospitals do mostly planned work – surgery, endoscopy, diagnostics and day procedures – funded by insurance, by ACC, by patients directly, and increasingly by Te Whatu Ora outsourcing planned operations.

For a clinician this matters in two ways. Many specialists work across both sectors in the same week: a public list on Tuesday, a private list on Thursday. And private hospitals are a substantial employer in their own right – theatre nurses, anaesthetic technicians, radiographers, sonographers and recovery staff. There are around seventeen new operating theatres in train across the city. It's worth knowing the landscape even if you only ever intend to work in the public system.

### **Beyond the hospitals**

Public and private hospitals are the two obvious employers. There are three more, and between them they account for a great deal of the clinical work in the region.

#### Primary care

General practices, most grouped into Primary Health Organisations, plus after-hours accident and medical clinics. GPs here are independent businesses rather than hospital employees.

*Roles: GPs, practice and specialist nurses, nurse practitioners, physiotherapists, sonographers, podiatrists.*

#### Community radiology

A significant part of Auckland's imaging happens outside hospitals, in community networks running their own MRI, CT, ultrasound and mammography. *Roles: radiographers, MRI and CT technologists, sonographers, mammographers, radiologists. Often more regular hours than a hospital roster.*

#### Community & NGO services

District nursing, home-based rehabilitation, aged residential care, hospice, mental-health and addiction services, and Māori and Pacific providers delivering care in their own communities.

*Roles: district and community nurses, occupational therapists, physiotherapists, speech-language therapists, psychologists, social workers.*

Why this matters when you're choosing a job

The same qualification opens quite different working lives here. A radiographer can be on a tertiary trauma roster, in a suburban community clinic, or moving between both.

If the hours matter more to you than the acuity – or the other way round – the sector you choose matters as much as the employer.

## FIVE WORKING LIVES, ONE QUALIFICATION

The sector you choose shapes the week more than the job title does. Same registration, same city – five quite different working lives, described here by what the week actually feels like rather than who the employer is.

|                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>A tertiary roster</b>            | Highest acuity, deepest subspecialty exposure, and a shift pattern built around a hospital that never closes. Nights, weekends and on-call are part of the deal.                     |
| <b>Planned-list work</b>            | Mostly booked, mostly daytime, in the private hospitals and increasingly on outsourced public lists. More predictable weeks; a narrower and less acute case mix.                     |
| <b>Primary care</b>                 | Continuity rather than episodes – the same families over years, in practices that are independent businesses. Wide scope, and clinical decisions made without a hospital behind you. |
| <b>Community imaging</b>            | Clinic-based scanning at volume, with regular hours far more often than a hospital roster allows. Technically demanding, without the acute pull.                                     |
| <b>Community, NGO and aged care</b> | Care delivered in homes, hospices and neighbourhoods. The most autonomy of any of these, the least immediate backup, and often the closest to the community you serve.               |

Many clinicians move between two of these over a career, or run two at once – a public list one day and a private or community list the next. Worth deciding which week you want before you decide which employer.

## Everyday care: enrol with a GP in your first month

Your GP is the front door to almost everything non-urgent. Enrolling with a practice near home means subsidised visits and a record that follows you; turning up as a casual patient costs considerably more. Many practices let you enrol online once you have a New Zealand address — do it before you need it, because popular practices near good schools sometimes close their books.

Dental care is private for adults, and prescriptions are partly subsidised once you’re enrolled. Pharmacies are everywhere, and pharmacists here are used to advising rather than just dispensing.

| What things cost           | Indicative NZ\$       |
|----------------------------|-----------------------|
| GP visit, enrolled adult   | \$50 – \$70           |
| GP visit, casual patient   | Higher                |
| Children under 14          | Usually free          |
| Prescription, per item     | Small standard charge |
| Dental check-up, adult     | \$90 – \$150          |
| Accident-related treatment | Covered by ACC        |

Indicative, and they change. Your practice publishes its own fees.

Do this in week one

Enrol the whole household with a GP near home, not near work.

Save 111 and Healthline in every phone in the family.

Find your nearest late-opening pharmacy and urgent care clinic.

## Four numbers worth knowing before you need them

111 · Emergency

Police, fire or ambulance. Ask for the service you need.

0800 611 116 · Healthline

Free advice from registered nurses, 24 hours a day. Use it early.

1737 · Mental health

Call or text, free, any time. Trained counsellors. Moving is hard — this is not a last resort.

105 · Police, non-urgent

For anything that matters but isn't happening right now.

Between the GP and the emergency department sit **accident and medical clinics** — walk-in, extended hours, and the right choice for most evening and weekend problems. Find your nearest one in your first week.

## Six things that work differently here

Not better or worse — different. Worth knowing before your first shift rather than during it.

Departments are smaller

Which cuts both ways: you carry a broader case mix, and you'll know the consultant, the radiographer and the ward clerk by name. Decisions get made in corridors rather than committees.

Te ao Māori is embedded, not added on

Karakia at the start of meetings, te reo on signage, whānau involved in decisions as a matter of course. Orientation will introduce Te Tiriti o Waitangi and tikanga — take it seriously.

Hierarchy is flatter

First names, fewer titles, and juniors expected to speak up. If you're used to a more formal culture this feels strange for a fortnight and excellent thereafter.

Geography is part of clinical practice

Patients travel. Retrieval, telehealth and regional referral are normal parts of the work in a country this shape, even in a city as large as Auckland.

Rosters are generally respected

Pressure exists — it's a health system. But finishing on time is closer to the norm than the exception, and annual leave is expected to be taken.

Auckland is the whole spectrum

From a tertiary centre with Starship next door to a hospital known nationally for trauma and burns. You can change the shape of your career without changing city.

*“The clinical standard here will not surprise you. What surprises people is how quickly they are trusted with real responsibility, and how normal it is to leave on time. Ask about the department, not just the job title — in a system this size, the team you join matters more than the letterhead.”*

SOPHIE CAREEM — FOUNDER & CEO, ETHICARE RESOURCING

## The questions that are awkward to ask in an interview

Will my family be covered?

Do I need private health insurance?

How quickly can I see a GP?

How do I see a specialist?

What about mental health support?

How the system is funded nationally, what ACC covers in detail and how enrolment works wherever you land is the same across the country — our [New Zealand healthcare guide](#) sets it out in full.

# Weekends & the outdoors

Auckland Guide · Chapter 9 of 9



Auckland has two coasts, forty minutes apart, and they couldn't be less alike. Knowing which one you want on a given day is most of what there is to learn — and what you do with the rest of the weekend is the reason people move here.

This is the chapter that sells the city, and also the one with the most important safety information in the guide. New Zealand's west-coast surf beaches are beautiful and genuinely dangerous, and the sun here burns faster than almost anywhere you've lived. Both are worth reading properly before your first summer.

## Two coasts, one isthmus

East is the Hauraki Gulf — sheltered, island-scattered, warm and calm. West is the Tasman Sea — black sand, open swell, and nothing between you and Australia. Most Aucklanders use both, for entirely different things.

Devonport, looking out across the gulf —  
twelve minutes by ferry from downtown

East · Hauraki Gulf

Golden sand, shallow entry, water that reaches the low twenties in February. Sheltered by the Coromandel and a scatter of islands, so the swell rarely amounts to much. Where families swim, where people go after work, and where you can leave a toddler at the water's edge without your heart rate changing.

West · Tasman Sea

Iron-black volcanic sand, cliffs, and surf that arrives with the whole Tasman behind it. Reached through rainforest, forty-five minutes from the city, and one of the great coastlines anywhere. It's also where people drown, most years, and almost always visitors who didn't understand what they were looking at.

40 min

Coast to coast, by car

15 min

City centre to the nearest swim

Feb

Warmest sea, not January

9pm

Summer daylight, after a shift

## Find your beach

Choosing by intention works far better than choosing by proximity – the nearest beach is frequently the wrong one for what you had in mind.

## Read this before your first west-coast swim

New Zealand has one of the higher drowning rates in the developed world, and the west-coast beaches account for a disproportionate share of it. The water looks inviting and the danger is invisible from the sand – which is precisely the problem.

As a clinician you'll recognise the pattern: confident adults, unfamiliar environment, no local knowledge, no perceived risk.

Five rules that cover almost all of it

**Swim between the flags.** They mark the only patrolled, rip-assessed stretch of water on the beach.

**If there are no flags, don't swim.** Unpatrolled west-coast beaches are not a judgement call for newcomers.

**Learn to spot a rip.** Calm, darker, flatter water between breaking waves isn't the safe bit – it's the current heading out.

**Caught in one, don't fight it.** Float, raise an arm, let it carry you out until it releases, then swim parallel to shore.

**Never swim alone, and never after drinking.** Almost every fatality involves one or both.

Surf Life Saving New Zealand publishes daily beach and hazard information at [safeswim.org.nz](https://safeswim.org.nz) (<https://safeswim.org.nz>) — water quality, rip risk, patrol status, and whether the beach is currently safe at all. Aucklanders check it before they drive out. So should you.

## Rainforest, thirty minutes from a hospital car park

Two ranges of subtropical bush sit at either end of the region, and there's a walking track across the middle of the city itself. None of it requires equipment beyond decent shoes and a raincoat.

Kauri dieback — please take this seriously

A soil-borne pathogen is killing kauri, the giant native tree the Waitākere Ranges exist to protect. Many tracks are closed, permanently in some cases.

Scrub your boots, use the disinfectant stations at both ends, and stay on the boardwalk — the spores travel in a gram of mud on your sole.

Closures change, so check Auckland Council before you set out rather than at the gate.

## The gulf is full of islands, and the ferry leaves from downtown

The sun, honestly

The UV here is fierce — a thinner ozone layer and cleaner air mean you burn far faster than at the same temperature in Europe.

It doesn't have to feel hot. Overcast days in October catch people out routinely.

Sunscreen, a hat and shade between eleven and four, every summer day. Skin cancer rates here are among the highest in the world, and you'll see the consequences at work.

*“I absolutely love Waiheke Island. We spent my birthday there and visited a couple of the wineries. The vineyards are beautiful and the views are incredible. It's probably one of my favourite days we've had since moving here.”*

FESTUS, RADIOGRAPHER — MOVED FROM LONDON TO AUCKLAND

Here are four versions of an Auckland weekend, and all four are ordinary. Not holidays — the sort of weekend people here have most weeks, in ordinary clothes, with the washing still to do on Sunday evening.

## Four weekends, same spine

The coast weekend

Friday dinner somewhere local, Saturday morning at the market, then west to Piha by ten and swimming by half past. Home sandy and early. Sunday is the Domain, a bakery and nothing much. *Furthest you travel: 45 min. Rough cost for two: modest.*

The island weekend

Ferry to Waiheke on Saturday morning, a vineyard lunch, a swim at Oneroa, and the six o'clock boat back full of people carrying wine and sandy towels. Sunday recovers. *Furthest you travel: 40 min by ferry.*

The city weekend

Brunch that takes two hours, the art gallery, Ponsonby Road in the afternoon, dinner in Britomart, and walking home along the water. Sunday is the Coast to Coast walkway if the weather holds.

The bush weekend

Waitākere Ranges on Saturday for a waterfall track and a village café on the way home. Sunday up Maungawhau before breakfast, then Cornwall Park with a flask. *Almost free.*

Costs are indicative for two adults, excluding fuel and anything you'd have spent at home anyway. The point is the shape of the day, not the arithmetic.

## Six habits you'll probably pick up

Not clubs and groups — those are in [Finding your people](#). These are the things people here simply do, that you likely didn't.

Checking the tide

Not the weather — the tide. Whether a beach is worth going to at two o'clock depends on it, and within a month you'll know without looking.

Keeping togs in the car

Swimming becomes something you do on the way home rather than something you plan. A towel lives in the boot from November.

Barbecuing on a Wednesday

It isn't an event here. Long evenings make cooking outside on a weeknight completely normal from October.

Going barefoot

In the supermarket, at the petrol station, at school pick-up. It stops being remarkable faster than you'd think.

Owning a chilly bin

And a trailer, or a friend with one. New Zealanders transport things constantly and are very relaxed about lending.

Watching the weather move

Four seasons in a day is accurate. You learn to go when it's fine rather than waiting for a better day.

## It would be dishonest to end on the beach

There's a real trade here, and it's worth naming before you decide rather than discovering in year two. None of these are reasons not to come. All of them are reasons to come with your eyes open.

Spontaneity with family

You can't drop in on anyone. Birthdays, funerals and bad news all happen twenty-four hours of flying away, and that doesn't get easier.

The cultural depth of a big city

Touring acts skip New Zealand or come once. Exhibitions are smaller. If the last Tuesday of every month was a concert, that changes.

Cheap weekends elsewhere

No Friday-night flight to another country for forty pounds. Travel from here is a proper undertaking, planned and paid for.

Being understood immediately

You'll explain where you're from for years. It's friendly, and it's also a small daily reminder that you arrived from somewhere else.

*“The thing that changes is not the weekends. It is that you stop saving them up. In a big northern city a good weekend takes planning and money and a train. Here you can decide at nine on a Saturday morning to drive to a beach, and be swimming by ten, and be home for lunch. It sounds small. It reorganises how a year feels.”*

SOPHIE CAREEM — FOUNDER & CEO, ETHICARE RESOURCING